

come together seamlessly. He bounds down the runway, much like the creature that gives his blade its name. Fourteen strides later, he takes off on his blade and flies into the sand pit. He repeats the drill multiple times until he is satisfied with his technique.

Then he heads to the gym. He switches his jumping blade for another prosthetic made of steel. Plates are loaded onto the bar, the weight steadily increasing until, at one point, there is over 200kg. More repetitions follow. It is hard work, but Solairaj knows this is what is required.

He already has impressive accomplishments. In 2023, Solairaj won gold in the men's long jump T64 category (for athletes with a lower-limb amputation) at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games. He also holds the Asian record of 7.08m. But in 2026, he wants more. "My goal is to win another Asian Games gold medal. I also want to jump 8 meters," he says.

They are lofty ambitions. Seven years ago, Solairaj was not dreaming of anything nearly as grand.

In November 2018, as he lay on a hospital bed at the Army Artificial Limb Centre (ALC) in Pune, Solairaj's mind was a muddle of confusion and depression. Around him were soldiers with missing arms and legs, waiting to be fitted with prosthetics. Soon, he would be one of them.

Complications from a tour of duty high in the mountains of Kargil had left a clot in his left leg, which worsened into nerve damage. Hope that the issue would resolve itself faded with time. As the limb turned black and swollen, doctors told him there was no option but to amputate below the knee to prevent further damage. At 23, he felt he was staring into the abyss.

"I genuinely didn't know what I was going to do. Would I ever be able to walk again? What was life going to be like now? How would people look at me? I felt ashamed of living my life as a crippled man. Those days I couldn't even speak Hindi that well so I didn't even understand what was going on around me," he recalls.

That was when, he remembers, a man sauntered into the ward. He was wearing shorts, flaunting a steel limb where his right leg should have been. He strode confidently up to Solairaj and introduced himself in Tamil as Naib Subedar Someswararao Ramudri.

Originally from Andhra Pradesh,

Fresh start: At the Army Paralympic Node in Pune, injury marks the beginning of a different discipline, where wounded soldiers are trained for elite para sport, not rehabilitation.

PICS: EMMANUAL YOGINI

